n8n Gmail Trigger Setup

Participant Guide: Connect Gmail to n8n using Google OAuth2 and test incoming email events

What you will build

In this exercise, you will connect a Gmail account to n8n so a workflow can detect new incoming messages. This is the first step in an email automation that can later summarize emails with an AI model and create reply drafts.

Gmail Trigger
Detect a new message

AI Agent
Summarize and draft a reply

Gmail Draft
Save for human review

Before you start

• An n8n account or local n8n installation.

• A Google/Gmail account you are authorized to connect.

• Access to Google Cloud Console to configure OAuth credentials if n8n requests a Client ID and Client Secret.

• Permission to enable the Gmail API and configure OAuth consent settings in the selected Google Cloud project.

Step 1 — Create or open your n8n workflow

1. Open your n8n instance.
2. Select **Create Workflow** (or open your existing workflow).
3. Click **Add first step** and search for **Gmail Trigger**.
4. Add the Gmail Trigger node to the canvas.

Step 2 — Configure the Gmail Trigger node

Setting	Recommended value	Purpose
Credential	Your connected Gmail account	Authorizes n8n to access Gmail
Poll Times → Mode	Every Minute (for testing)	Checks periodically for new messages
Event	Message Received	Triggers when a new message is detected
Simplify	ON	Makes output easier to use
Max Emails per Poll	10	Limits how many messages are returned per poll
Filters	Leave blank initially	Add filters later if needed

Step 3 — Enable the Gmail API in Google Cloud

Use this only if your credential setup requires you to create your own OAuth client.
1. Open Google Cloud Console and select the project used for n8n.
2. Open **APIs & Services** → **Library** (or search the API Library).
3. Search for **Gmail API** and click **Enable**.
4. Continue to Google Auth Platform / OAuth consent settings.

Step 4 — Configure the OAuth consent / Audience settings

Google's menus may appear as **Google Auth Platform** → **Branding, Audience, Clients** or as **APIs & Services** → **OAuth consent screen**.
1. Enter an app name such as **n8n Gmail Automation**.
2. Provide a support email and developer contact email.
3. For a personal Gmail account, choose **External** if Google asks for an audience type.
4. If the app is in **Testing** mode, open **Audience** → **Test users** → **Add users** and add the Google account you will connect.
5. Save changes.

Important: Add the account that will authorize n8n. If you use a different Google Cloud project or OAuth client from the one configured in n8n, the test-user change may not fix access.

Step 5 — Create the OAuth Client ID

1. Open **Google Auth Platform** → **Clients** or **APIs & Services** → **Credentials**.
2. Click **Create client** / **Create credentials** → **OAuth client ID**.
3. Choose **Web application**.
4. Give it a name such as **n8n Gmail Automation**.
5. Leave **Authorized JavaScript origins** empty for a typical local n8n setup.
6. Under **Authorized redirect URIs**, add the exact callback URL shown inside your n8n Gmail credential.
7. Click **Create** and copy the Client ID and Client Secret into n8n.

Do not blindly copy a localhost callback URL if your n8n is hosted online. Always use the redirect URL displayed by your own n8n credential. The URL must match exactly.

Step 6 — Save and authorize the n8n credential

1. In n8n, open the Gmail credential from the Gmail Trigger node.
2. Paste the Google **Client ID** and **Client Secret** into the matching fields.
3. Save the credential if required.
4. Click **Sign in with Google**.
5. Select the correct Google account and review the permissions.
6. Click **Allow** to authorize the connection.
7. Return to n8n and confirm that the credential is connected.

Step 7 — Test the Gmail Trigger

1. Return to the Gmail Trigger node.
2. Keep **Event = Message Received** and the other settings shown in Step 2.
3. Click **Fetch Test Event** (or the equivalent test/listen control in your n8n version).
4. If no email is found, send a new test email to the connected Gmail account and try again.
5. Inspect the OUTPUT panel for fields such as the message ID, sender, subject, and message body. The exact field names depend on the node output.

Sample test email

Subject	Request for Power BI Training
Body	Dear Sir, We are interested in arranging a two-day Power BI workshop for 20 employees. Please share the proposed topics and training fee. Regards, HR Manager

Step 8 — Build the full email AI automation

After the trigger works, extend the workflow in this order:
Gmail Trigger → (optional Gmail Get Message) → AI Agent + Chat Model → Gmail Create Draft

• Use the Gmail Get Message node if the trigger output does not contain the complete email body.
• In the AI Agent prompt, pass the sender, subject, and body using the actual fields shown in the node output.
• In the system instructions, ask the AI to summarize the email and draft a concise professional reply without inventing facts.
• Connect a supported chat model and configure its credentials.
• Use the Gmail node's Draft → Create operation, if available, to save the reply for review.

Safety recommendation: Start by saving replies as drafts. Do not automatically send replies until the workflow has been tested carefully and you have defined clear approval rules.

Troubleshooting Guide

Error / issue	What to check
Access blocked / Error 403: access_denied	If OAuth app is in Testing mode, add the authorizing account under Audience → Test users in the same Google Cloud project used by the OAuth client.
Unable to sign without access token	Open the n8n Gmail credential and complete Google authorization again. Confirm Client ID/Secret and redirect URI.
redirect_uri_mismatch	Copy the callback URL from n8n and ensure it exactly matches an Authorized redirect URI in Google Cloud.
Gmail API not enabled	Enable Gmail API in the Google Cloud project used for the OAuth client.
No test event returned	Send a new email to the connected mailbox, retry the trigger test, and inspect the node output. Confirm the credential is connected.
OAuth menus look different	Google may show Google Auth Platform (Branding, Audience, Clients) or the older APIs & Services menu labels.

Security checklist

• Never share your Google Client Secret or access tokens.

• Authorize only the Google account you intend to use for the automation.

• Use the minimum permissions needed for your workflow.

• Keep reply generation in draft mode while testing.

• Review the email body before enabling any automatic-send action.

Useful official resources

• n8n Gmail Trigger documentation
• n8n Gmail message operations
• Google Cloud Console
• Google Auth Platform — Audience